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US Midterms: Many Armenian Americans Win Local, State, Federal Positions

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(The California Courier)-U.S. Midterm elections took place on Tuesday, November 6, with a number of Armenian-American candidates vying for local, state and federal positions.

In the U.S. House of Representatives, Armenian American Democrat Anna Eshoo, who represents California's 18th District, and Democrat Jackie Kanchelian Speier, who represents California's 14th Congressional District were both re-elected. Both are members of the Congressional Armenian Caucus, of which Speier is presently a co-chair.

In California's 28th Congressional District, Republican Johnny Nalbandian was defeated by incumbent Democrat Adam Schiff; with all precincts reporting November 6, Schiff had 76 percent of the vote, to Nalbandian's 23.5 percent. The district covers much of Burbank, Hollywood, West Hollywood and Silver Lake. Schiff has been a longtime champion of Armenian-American issues, and is presently a co-vice chair of the Congressional Armenian Caucus.

In Nevada's 3rd Congressional District, Armenian American Republican Danny Tarkanian ran a spirited campaign but lost to Democrat Susie Lee. Tarkanian trailed with 43.4 percent of the vote to Lee's 51.4 percent, and conceded the race on Wednesday, November 7.

The New York 22nd Congressional District race between Armenian-American Democrat Anthony Brindisi and Republican Claudia Tenney, had yet to be decided as of November 12 at which time Brindisi led Tunney by 1,293 votes. On election night, Brindisi gave a victory speech, but Tunney has not yet conceded as more than 16,000 absentee ballots need to be counted, along with provisional and military ballots.

In the central portion of the San Fernando Valley of Los Angeles, Democrat Adrin Nazarian-who heads the Armenian Legislative Issues Caucus-held on against Republican challenger Roxanne Hoge for Assembly District 46, which encompasses areas including North Hills, Panorama City, Van Nuys and North Hollywood. Nazarian was up 77.9 percent to Hoge's 22.1 percent.

In the California State Senate-covering cities including Whittier, Cerritos, Downey, Norwalk and Hacienda Heights-Republican challenger Rita Topalian lost to Democrat Bob Archuleta, former mayor of Pico Rivera, who won the election by 65 percent.

Mari Manoogian, Democratic candidate for Michigan's 40th State House district, defeated her opponent former Michigan GOP vice chair David Wolkinson 57 percent to 43 percent in the midterm elections. Manoogian, who was born and raised in Birmingham, Michigan, received an array of endorsements from federal, state and local leaders including President Barack Obama, Senator Gary Peters and Governor-Elect Gretchen Whitmer, also received multiple endorsements from local media, union and civic organizations.

Armenian-American candidate Sara Gideon, a Democratic member of the Maine House of Representatives, won the seat representing the 48th District.

First elected in 2012, Gideon was reelected in 2014 and chosen as Assistant Majority Leader of the Maine House of Representatives.

Gideon served as the speaker of the House; she served as assistant majority leader from 2014 to 2016. Gideon was born in Rhode Island. Her father immigrated to America from India and worked as a pediatrician. She is married and

has three children.

California State Assembly Candidate Elizabeth Warren (not to be confused with United States Senator Elizabeth Warren) the granddaughter of Armenian genocide survivors who was running for California's 76th District-which includes the Marine Base at Camp Pendleton, and the cities of Carlsbad, Vista, Encinitas and Oceanside-was defeated by fellow Democrat opponent Tasha Boerner Horvath. Where Boerner Horvath's message pulled more toward the center, Warren ran a more activist campaign, focusing on issues such as Medicare for all and free education.

Anna Astvatsaturian Turcotte was re-elected to serve Ward Three on Westbrook, Maine's City Council in midterm elections. Turcotte first ran and won the seat in 2015 and was at that time the youngest and only female city council representative on the Westbrook City Council. Turcotte, a refugee from Baku, Azerbaijan, is an Armenian-American author, activist, attorney and lecturer who is also a staunch advocate for increased U.S. aid for Artsakh, the right to selfdetermination for Artsakh and other Armenian issues including recognition of the Armenian Genocide.

Lorig Charkoudian, the Democratic candidate for Maryland's House of Delegates was elected to serve as one of the three delegates for District 20, becoming the first Armenian-American in recent memory (and, perhaps ever) to serve in the Maryland state legislature.

Charkoudian, originally from Newton, Mass., has been in public service for more than two decades.

The Armenian National Committee of America (ANCA) issued its endorsements in advance of the midterm elections, which included Eshoo, Speier, Schiff, Tarkanian, Brindisi, Nazarian, Manoogian, Gideon, Warren, Turcotte and Charkoudian.

In California, the ANCA endorsed California Democrat Gavin Newsom who was elected as governor; Democrat Eleni Kounalakis elected as Lt.

Governor; Democrat Alex Padilla as Secretary of State; Democrat Betty Yee as State Controller; Democrat Fiona Ma as State Treasurer; and Democrat Ricardo Lara as Insurance Commissioner.

According to early election results, over 165 ANCAendorsed candidates-roughly 92 percent of the 180 formally backed by the pro-Armenian advocacy organization-won election to the U.S. Senate and House.

The ANCA endorsed congressional candidates including Judy Chu (D-Calif.), Jim Costa (D-Calif.), Tulsi Gabbard (D-Hawaii), Grace Napolitano (D-Calif.), Ted Lieu (D-Calif.), Devin Nunes (R-Calif.), Linda Sanchez (D-Calif.), Brad Sherman (D-Calif.), and David Valadao (R-Calif.), who won re-election to their respective districts.

Five Congressional Armenian Caucus leaders, including cochair Frank Pallone (D-N.J.), and David Valadao (R-Calif.), and co-vice chair Gus Bilirakis (R-Fla.) were re-elected.

Senator Bob Menendez (D-N.J.), a leading Senate champion of Armenian American priorities was re-elected, and will return to the Senate as the Ranking Democrat on the influential Foreign Relations Committee.

In the California state legislature, Republican Andreas Borgeas was elected to the California State Senate to represent District 8 in Central California.

In the California State Assembly, Speaker Anthony Rendon (D-Calif.) of the 63rd District was reelected as well as Majority Floor Leader Ian Calderon (D-Calif.).

Assembly member Laura Friedman (D-Calif.) representing the largest Armenian-American constituency in California was re-elected. Assembly members Evan Low (D-Calif.) and Autumn Burke (D-Calif.), were re-elected. Other close friends of the community, including Chris Holden (D-Calif.), Jesse Gabriel (D-Calif.), and Luz Rivas (D-Calif.), also

won re-election.

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